



WASHINGTON STATE

Flock camera limits, income tax among measures WA lawmakers passed this year

By **Simone Carter**

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The 2026 Washington legislative session commenced on January 12, with 98 representatives and 49 senators reconvening in Olympia. This year's 60-day session follows the fiery debates of 2025. Lawmakers began prefiling bills on December 1, 2025, with the session expected to conclude on March 12, 2026. Gov. Bob Ferguson has until April 4 to act on legislation. By Liesbeth Powers

✦ Key Takeaways

AI-generated summary reviewed by our newsroom.

After bruising tax fights and a [controversy](#) or [two](#), Washington lawmakers arrived at the domed Capitol building in Olympia Thursday for the last scheduled day of this year's session, called Sine Die.

The past 60 days have been action-packed as Democratic legislators raced to write and pass an [income tax on millionaires](#).

That tax fight commanded both news headlines and much of state lawmakers' time. Earlier this week a House debate about the proposal [lasted more than 24 hours](#).

Other big bills crossed the finish line, too, including one aimed at imposing restrictions on [automated license plate readers](#) (ALPR), like those run by Flock Safety.

[Senate Bill 6002](#) by Sen. Yasmin Trudeau, a Tacoma Democrat, creates regulations for using ALPR systems and limits their use by local and state agencies. Data generally must be deleted within three weeks, with certain exceptions.

Many local jurisdictions across Washington state have considered suspending their ALPR system, including [Olympia](#) and [Everett](#).

Proponents of the cameras note that they can help law enforcement [solve crimes](#), but opponents argue that they've also been exploited by [stalkers and domestic abusers](#). Others don't like that the system has been used to share data for [federal immigration enforcement purposes](#).

Trudeau told McClatchy on Thursday that the measure will ensure there's "real accountability for people that do not follow the law."

“And the law now is that the data stays in Washington for the purposes of solving serious crimes that are listed in the bill,” she said. “I feel like that’s a really huge win.”

Democratic and Republican leadership sat down with the public affairs network TVW on Thursday to reflect on the 2026 session.

Gov. Bob Ferguson told TVW that under his priority income-tax legislation, [Senate Bill 6346](#), thousands of small businesses will no longer pay the state’s business and occupation tax. Plus, hundreds of thousands of additional families will [be eligible](#) to receive a rebate under the Working Families Tax Credit, he said.

“It’s not just about more money for our general fund — that’s nice to have — but it’s about reinvesting back to the people to make sure that life is more affordable for them here in Washington state,” he said.

SB 6346 is headed to [Ferguson’s desk](#) after the Senate agreed Wednesday to changes made by the House. The bill would impose a 9.9% tax on annual household earnings above \$1 million.

Ferguson insists that he’s against lowering the threshold for the tax, as critics worry could someday happen.

Senate Minority Leader John Braun told TVW that he thinks the income tax will inflict long-term damage on the economy and the state’s standard of living. The Centralia Republican has argued that the tax would [drive entrepreneurs](#) and businesses out of state.

On Thursday Braun gave a nod to lawmakers’ move to roll back a new estate tax rate passed last year, [from 35%](#) to the previous top tier of 20%.

The majority party further sought to distance the state from federal immigration enforcement this year.

Democrats passed a bill barring law enforcement officers, including those from Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE), from [donning masks](#) while interacting with the public. Another measure on Ferguson's desk prohibits people from impersonating an officer by wearing clothes, displaying a badge or using a vehicle bearing the insignia of a law enforcement agency, such as ICE.

As for what's to come next session, Ferguson said he'll again push for greater investment in the state's ferries. Senate Majority Leader Jamie Pedersen, a Seattle Democrat, told TVW that lawmakers will likely look to change the property-tax system to include different rates for residential and commercial properties and "figure out potentially how to have a significant homestead exemption for people."

House Speaker Laurie Jenkins, a Tacoma Democrat, told the network that lawmakers this year sought to combat "harm" coming from the federal level.

Budget writers noted Wednesday that they'd worked to backfill recent [federal funding cuts](#).

House Minority Leader Drew Stokesbary of Auburn told TVW that Washington Democrats often cast blame on Washington, D.C. for tariffs driving up prices in the state. The Republican argued it's the state's policies that have made it less affordable over time.

One measure awaiting Ferguson's signature is Sen. John Lovick's [Senate Bill 5974](#), which establishes stricter eligibility requirements for law enforcement leaders and allows [decertified sheriffs](#) to get booted from office. The Mill Creek Democrat, who once served as Snohomish County sheriff, has argued the measure sets clear conduct standards and holds officials to account.

Lovick was also behind a proposal to lower the state's legal [blood alcohol concentration limit](#) for drivers from 0.08% to 0.05%. He told TVW that much of the world already operates under that 0.05% BAC level, and he was disappointed the state didn't ultimately follow suit this session.

“I take full responsibility for not getting this .05 over the finish line,” he said, “and I’m going to keep working on it until we get it done.”

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